



BEFORE

Opposition to slavery began in the colonial era, but in the 30 years prior to the Civil War, abolitionist organizations formed to promote freedom at the local and national level.

RELIGIOUS INSPIRATION

Few white Americans actively opposed slavery before 1830, but the **abolition of slavery** in many **Northern states**, by the **British Empire**, and in most of the **new nations of Latin America** marked its **continuation in the American South** as an **anomaly**.

Numerous **religious revivalist movements**, particularly across the North, stimulated newly energized evangelicals to seek the perfection of American society by **eliminating shameful social and political evils**, such as slavery.

DIFFERING APPROACHES

White abolitionists attacked slavery as a **moral and political evil** even as they disagreed among themselves about how abolition should be achieved. One faction demanded **immediate emancipation** and complete political equality. They would tolerate **no compromises with enslavers** and offered no compensation. **Gradualists** hoped to **minimize social and economic upheaval** by emancipating slaves gradually and providing enslavers with some kind of compensation.

David Walker, a free Black man, wrote his *Appeal to the Colored Citizens of the World* in 1829, demanding the immediate abolition of slavery. Echoing the Declaration of Independence, he asserted that Black people were Americans and entitled to the rights of citizens. He denounced moderate anti-slavery leaders who advocated sending free Black people to the struggling colony of Liberia, and accused the United States of hypocrisy as a Christian nation.

Shortly after its publication, copies of Walker's *Appeal* were discovered in South Carolina, Georgia, Virginia, and Louisiana, carried South by free Black sailors. White Southerners feared that free Black people and sympathetic Northerners were inciting slaves to rebellion. To prevent insurrections, most Southern states banned teaching Black people—slave or free—to read.

Rebellion in Virginia

In 1831, Southerners' worst fears were realized when the enslaved person Nat Turner led an insurrection in Southampton County, Virginia. Turner and his allies swiftly moved between isolated farms, killing all the whites they encountered, some 70 people in all.